IELTS Listening Practice Test

Transcript — Parts 1–4 · Episode 10

PART 1

You will hear a telephone conversation between a woman booking a community cooking class and a customer service representative. You now have some time to look at questions 1 to 10.

Speaker B: Good morning, City Community Centre bookings, this is Thomas speaking. How can I help you today?

Speaker A: Hello, I'm calling to book a spot on one of your upcoming cooking classes. I saw a flyer for them at the local library.

Speaker B: Of course! We have a few different options coming up. Was there a particular type of cooking you were interested in?

Speaker A: Yes, I'm really keen on the artisan bread making class. I've tried baking at home, but my loaves never turn out quite right.

Speaker B: Ah, the artisan bread making class is wonderful. It's very popular. Let me check the schedule for that one. We have a session starting on the twelfth of October. Oh, hold on, actually, that one is completely full. The next one with space is on the nineteenth of October. Would that date work for you?

Speaker A: Yes, the nineteenth of October is fine. I can definitely make that.

Speaker B: Perfect. I'll reserve a place for you. I just need to take down some of your details to complete the booking form. Can I have your full name, please?

Speaker A: It's Sarah Harries.

Speaker B: Could you spell your last name for me, please?

Speaker A: Yes, it's H-A-R-R-I-E-S.

Speaker B: Thank you, Sarah. And what is a good contact number for you?

Speaker A: It's 0-1-6-3-2-9-6-0-2-1-4.

Speaker B: Got it, 0-1-6-3-2-9-6-0-2-1-4. Do you also have a local postcode we can put down for our community records?

Speaker A: Yes, my postcode is SW15 3PP.

Speaker B: Great, thank you. Now, do you have any dietary requirements or food allergies we should let the chef know about?

Speaker A: I don't have any allergies, but I am on a strict gluten-free diet. Will that be an issue for a bread class?

Speaker B: Not at all! The chef actually runs a gluten-free version of the class specifically for participants with those needs, so we will make sure you are in that group.

Speaker A: That's fantastic. I'm so glad to hear that.

Speaker B: Now, let's look at the payment. The standard price is fifty-five pounds. Wait, sorry, let me check that again... yes, there is a seasonal discount of seven pounds, so the actual price you'll pay today is forty-eight pounds.

Speaker A: Oh, that's a nice surprise. Thank you. Do I need to pay the whole amount now?

Speaker B: No, you only need to pay a ten-pound deposit today to secure your spot, and then you can pay the remaining balance on the day of the class.

Speaker A: Excellent. I can do that.

Speaker B: Wonderful. Your booking reference number is 9-8-2-4-5-1.

Speaker A: Let me write that down... 9-8-2-4-5-1. Got it. And where exactly is the class held?

Speaker B: It takes place at our main facility on High Street, specifically in the Oak Room. It has a fully equipped demonstration kitchen.

Speaker A: Okay, the Oak Room. And what time does it start?

Speaker B: The class starts at six-thirty pm, but we ask everyone to arrive about fifteen minutes early to get settled in.

Speaker A: Great, I'll make sure to be there by six-fifteen. Thank you so much for your help!

Speaker B: You're very welcome, Sarah. We look forward to seeing you there!

PART 2

You will hear a talk by a local community coordinator giving an introduction to the Oakwood Community Garden project. You now have some time to look at questions 11 to 20.

Speaker A: Welcome, everyone, to the annual introduction talk for the Oakwood Community Garden. It's wonderful to see so many new faces here today. Let me start by giving you a bit of background about how this whole project got started. Our beautiful garden wasn't always the lush, green sanctuary you see today. Five years ago, this plot of land was completely empty, a neglected concrete yard that had been abandoned for decades. While some residents suggested building cheap housing or a playground, a small group of us realized we needed a shared green space to transform this neglected urban area. It wasn't about growing cheap food, though that has been a wonderful bonus, but about bringing life and beauty back to our neighborhood. When we first got access to the land, we had grand ideas about building raised beds and planting fruit trees straight away. However, the reality of the site quickly brought us down to earth. Before we could even think about testing the soil quality or erecting a protective wooden fence, our primary and most grueling task was to clear away the literal mountain of rubbish that had accumulated over the years. It took twenty volunteers three full weekends just to remove the broken glass, old metal, and plastic waste. Only then could we begin the rewarding work of planting. Over the years, people often ask how we keep the garden running, particularly when it comes to finances. In our first year, we relied on municipal grants, but those are highly competitive and eventually dried up. We also tried selling our fresh produce to visitors on weekends, but the income was too unpredictable. Today, our primary source of ongoing funding is the generous annual donations we receive from local businesses in the Oakwood area. In return, we display their logos on our main entrance board, which has turned out to be a fantastic partnership for everyone involved. Now, if you're looking to visit or get involved, we have various events throughout the week. On Wednesday afternoons, we host a particularly popular session. While many people assume this is when we harvest our crops or sell handmade crafts, it is actually when we hold our free gardening workshop. Anyone can turn up and learn essential skills, from composting to organic pest control, led by our head horticulturalist. Finally, for those who want a more personal stake in the garden, we do have a limited number of private allotment plots available for rent. Due to extremely high demand, we had to establish strict eligibility rules. Unfortunately, we cannot offer these plots to anyone living across the entire city, nor do we restrict them solely to families with young children. To keep the project truly local, plots are strictly reserved for residents who live within our specific postcode area. Now, let's move on to some of our garden guidelines and how you can participate as a volunteer. To ensure the garden remains a safe and pleasant environment for everyone, we have established a few basic rules. First and foremost, we have a large collection of high-quality gardening tools available for everyone to use. We ask that all tools must be returned to the wooden shed at the back of the garden immediately after you finish using them, rather than leaving them lying on the paths where they could pose a tripping hazard. When it comes to watering the plants, we try to be as environmentally friendly as possible. We do not use tap water. Instead, all water should be sourced directly from the rain tank that is positioned right next to the main gate. This collects runoff from our greenhouse roof and is highly beneficial for the plants. Safety is also a top priority. The ground can be uneven and there are occasionally sharp thorns or heavy objects. Therefore, we insist that all volunteers must wear sturdy shoes at all times while working in the garden. Sandals or open-toed footwear are strictly prohibited. We also believe in collaborative decision-making. To keep everyone informed and to plan for the future, we hold monthly meetings. These are held on the first Saturday of every month, and we encourage everyone to attend to discuss our upcoming events. Lastly, we love seeing families in the garden, and it is a wonderful place for young ones to learn about nature. However, for safety reasons, children must always remain under constant adult supervision. There are deep ponds and sharp tools around, so they must never be left to wander alone.

PART 3

You will hear a conversation between three university students discussing their joint research project on renewable energy systems. You now have some time to look at questions 21 to 30.

Speaker A: Hey Bella, hey Charles, thanks for meeting up today. We really need to get our heads together and finalize our plans for the renewable energy research project.

Speaker B: Absolutely, Arthur. The deadline is creeping up on us. I've been looking over our initial background research on wind energy. I have to say, I was really surprised by some of the findings.

Speaker C: Me too. I thought the most striking thing would be the high cost of turbine maintenance, but actually, that has dropped significantly. What shocked me was just how fast the technology has developed over the last five years.

Speaker B: Exactly! It's gone from a niche alternative to a mainstream powerhouse much quicker than anyone predicted. I mean, public support has always been relatively high, but the technological leap is what really stood out.

Speaker A: I agree. Now, speaking of our research, we need to address the change in our main research question. Initially, we wanted to look at national energy grids, but we've had to narrow our focus.

Speaker B: Yes, it's a good thing our supervisor suggested we zoom in on local systems. We originally wanted to analyze national data, but we quickly realized we simply couldn't access enough national data to make that approach feasible.

Speaker C: Right, and it's much better than doing the exact same broad topic as the other student group in our class. Focusing on our local county's wind farm makes our project much more manageable and unique.

Speaker B: Definitely. Now, Charles, you suggested using case studies for the qualitative section. What do you both think about that?

Speaker A: I was skeptical at first because I thought analyzing individual case studies would take up too much of our limited time. But looking at it now, they provide far more realistic insights than just looking at raw statistics.

Speaker B: I agree with Arthur. Statistics can tell us how much energy is produced, but case studies show us the actual impact on local communities and how they overcome operational challenges.

Speaker C: Great, I'm glad we're on the same page. Now, how are we going to gather our primary data? We talked about doing online surveys or maybe observing energy consumption at a local school.

Speaker B: I think online surveys are too unreliable—the response rate is usually very low. And observing a school would require too much paperwork for ethical clearance.

Speaker C: That's true. What if we interview local factory managers instead? They can give us direct, practical data on how industrial energy use has changed since the local wind farm was established.

Speaker A: That's a brilliant idea. It's highly targeted and they're likely to have precise energy records.

Speaker B: Agreed. Let's make that our primary data collection method. Now, looking at our schedule, what is our absolute priority for next Monday? Our supervisor wants to see our progress.

Speaker A: Well, we've started the literature review, but that isn't due for another three weeks.

Speaker C: And we can't write the methodology section until we've actually conducted the interviews.

Speaker B: Right, so we must complete the draft questionnaire for the factory managers by Monday, so our supervisor can review and approve it before we send it out.

Speaker A: Okay, draft questionnaire is the priority for Monday. Let's make sure we have it ready.

Speaker C: Now, let's divide up the remaining tasks for the project so we can work efficiently over the next couple of weeks.

Speaker B: Good idea. We have five main tasks left: formatting the bibliography, creating the slide presentation, contacting the university statistics department for advice on data analysis, proofreading the final draft of the report, and designing the research poster for the exhibition.

Speaker A: Well, I'm happy to handle the bibliography. I've used the citation software before, so formatting all the references correctly won't take me long at all.

Speaker B: Thanks, Arthur, that'll be a huge help. What about the slide presentation? I think it would be best if Charles did that, since he's great with visual design.

Speaker C: I'd love to do the slides, but actually, I think we should all work on the slides together once the report is finished, to ensure we are all comfortable with the content we'll be presenting.

Speaker B: That makes sense. We'll collaborate on the slide presentation together as a team.

Speaker A: What about contacting the statistics department? We need someone to set up a meeting with their advisors to help us analyze our survey results.

Speaker C: I can take care of that. I have a friend who works in that department, so I can easily get in touch with them and set up an appointment for us.

Speaker B: Excellent, thanks Charles. That leaves proofreading the final draft of the report and designing the research poster.

Speaker A: I think Bella should definitely do the proofreading. You have a real eye for spotting grammatical errors and typos, Bella.

Speaker B: Haha, okay, I don't mind doing that. I'll do a thorough read-through of our final draft before we submit it.

Speaker C: And that leaves the research poster. I'm happy to take full responsibility for designing that, as I've got some graphic design software on my laptop that will make it look highly professional.

Speaker A: Perfect! That's a solid plan. Let's get to work.

PART 4

You will hear a lecture by an archaeologist on the history and development of ancient maritime trade routes in the Indian Ocean. You now have some time to look at questions 31 to 40.

Speaker A: Good morning, everyone. Today, we are going to explore the fascinating history of maritime trade routes in the Indian Ocean, a vast network of exchange that shaped ancient civilizations and connected diverse cultures across thousands of miles. To understand the origins of this network, we must go back to around three thousand BCE. The earliest maritime trade in this region was not driven by the search for luxury goods like gold or silks, but rather by the necessity of acquiring raw materials. In particular, the exchange of copper from the Arabian Peninsula was the primary catalyst for early sea journeys. This essential metal was shipped across the Persian Gulf to the emerging urban centers of Mesopotamia, establishing the very first regular maritime corridors. These early sailors faced immense navigational challenges. Without modern instruments, they had to rely entirely on the natural world. Most crucial of all were the monsoon winds. These seasonal winds reverse their direction twice a year, blowing from the northeast in winter and from the southwest in summer. By understanding and utilizing these patterns, ancient mariners could travel long distances across the open ocean, confident that the wind would eventually carry them home. The construction of the vessels themselves was also highly adapted to the unique conditions of the Indian Ocean. Unlike European shipbuilders who secured their wooden vessels with iron nails, builders in this region developed a different technique. Ships were constructed using wooden planks that were literally sewn together using strong cords made from coconut fiber. This method resulted in flexible hulls that could withstand the impact of crashing waves and shallow coral reefs far better than rigid metal-fastened boats. As the centuries progressed, maritime trade entered a golden age, marked by major technological and economic innovations. One of the most significant breakthroughs was the development of the lateen sail. This triangular sail, which could be pivoted to catch the wind at different angles, allowed ships to sail against the wind for the first time, liberating traders from strict reliance on seasonal patterns. With the ability to travel more freely, major ports grew rapidly along the coasts of India, East Africa, and the Arabian Peninsula. These ports functioned as vital hubs not just for regional survival, but for the global exchange of luxury commodities. While textiles and precious stones were traded in large numbers, it was the trade in spices, such as black pepper and cinnamon, that generated the greatest wealth and drove merchants to venture further than ever before. To facilitate these complex, long-distance transactions, merchants had to innovate economically. Carrying heavy cargo of metal coins was not only physically challenging but also highly risky due to the threat of piracy. To solve this, merchants developed an advanced system of credit. This allowed a trader to deposit funds in one port and withdraw them in another, thousands of miles away, utilizing trusted networks of financial agents.

However, this massive expansion of maritime trade was not without its consequences. The environmental impact on coastal regions was profound. The constant demand for new, larger merchant vessels led to severe over-harvesting of coastal timber. Entire forests of oak and teak were cleared to supply the shipyards, leading to soil erosion and permanent changes to the local ecology. In modern times, our understanding of these ancient trade networks has been greatly enriched by archaeology. Modern archaeological digs along coastal sites have uncovered vast quantities of ancient pottery, much of it originating from China and Persia. Because ceramic styles changed predictably over time, these durable artifacts help researchers map out precise chronological routes and trade partnerships. Unfortunately, many of these invaluable historical sites are now under severe threat. Rapidly rising sea levels and intense coastal erosion have begun to destroy several ancient port ruins. Consequently, local conservationists are calling for immediate protection measures to preserve these fragile archaeological deposits before they are washed away. Fortunately, the field of maritime archaeology has been revolutionized by technology. Researchers no longer rely solely on shallow dives to locate historical remains. Today, marine archaeologists use advanced sonar technology to scan the ocean floor in deep water. This has allowed them to locate and map incredibly well-preserved shipwrecks that were previously completely inaccessible, opening a new window into the rich maritime history of the Indian Ocean.